

of USB sticks—fell in the third category, *Micro-drive-based hard drives*.

What's to be tested in an external hard drive? After all, they're just boxes for your data, right? Well, they can be differentiated according to their targeted consumer segment. There are large differences, such as their interface, whether there are dedicated buttons to back up data, how sleek they are, the software they come bundled with, as well as their speeds and prices—amongst other variables.

So we tested them, and here's what we found.

PORTABLE HARD DRIVES

The drives in this category target the consumer who does not need to use the drive on a regular basis, such as a home user who only needs to back up data occasionally. Such a user might also find an external disk useful when he wishes to swap music and movies with friends and doesn't want to open—or doesn't feel like opening—his cabinet. Naturally, these drives do not include high-end features such as FireWire ports.

A bulk of the drives we received—10 drives out of the 18—come under this segment. Of these, two were from Freecom, one from Iomega, three from LaCie, one from Seagate, two from Transcend, and one from Western Digital (WD).

Features Capacities And RPM

Capacities range from a modest 30 GB to a good 120 GB. The LaCie Skwarim is 30 GB, which is internally a Hitachi HTC42603 Travelstar C4K60 drive. There were two 120 GB hard drives—the LaCie Rugged RUG U2 and the WD Passport.

The rotational speeds, or rpm, of the drives is 4200 rpm for Freecom FHD-XS, Freecom FHD-2 PRO, LaCie Skwarim 30 GB and Transcend StoreJet 40 GB; 5400 rpm for the Iomega 80 GB, LaCie Rugged RUG U2, LaCie Design by F. A. Porsche 40 GB, Seagate 40 GB, Transcend StoreJet 80 GB, and the Western Digital Passport 120 GB. The higher the rpm, the higher the data read and write speeds, at least theoretically.

Interfaces

The interface is USB 2.0 with all these drives. All computers these days come with motherboards with USB 2.0 ports, which support a peak data throughput of 480 Mbps—fast enough to back up your data: for example, theoretically, a 700 MB DivX movie can be transferred in around 12 seconds, though in reality the figures are different. These drives are backwards-compatible with USB 1.1, which means you can use them with older computers. Of course, data transfer will be much slower.

Bundled Software

All the drives came bundled with some kind of backup or data synchronisation software. The Freecom drives came with the Personal Media Suite, which synchronises your data at the press of a button on the drive. Acronis True Image—a good and fast data backup and drive

imaging software, which has simple Wizards that first-time users will find easy to use—also came bundled with these drives. The LaCie drives came with 1-Click, another good backup software. The WD Passport box was marked “WD Sync software included”, but there was no CD inside; we later found that the software was on the drive. If you purchase the WD Passport, back up the software before you start using the drive—it is a file synchronisation software.

The Iomega came with FolderShare, a synchronisation software that allows you to synchronise your data over the Internet! You'd want to use this feature to, say, synchronise data on a daily basis between your office and home computers.

The StoreJet suite software bundled with the Transcend drives consists of several utilities. The StoreJet PC Lock software can be used to securely lock your OS: it gets locked when the drive is unplugged, and you unlock your OS when you plug the drive back in. Security HDD is an Explorer-like file manager that stores files on these drives by compressing and encrypting them. Mobile Internet Explorer, Mobile Outlook Express and Mobile Address Book let you get online from any computer using your customisations such as bookmarks, e-mail accounts, etc., and all these can be stored on the drives. The applications—Mobile Internet Explorer and so on—appear on the Device Desktop panel, which is something like a toolbar. This lets you carry your Desktop anywhere.

Cables And Accessories

All the drives came with regular USB cables, except those that had retractable ones—the Freecom FHD-XS and the LaCie Skwarim. The retractable cables sit inside the drive case, and can be pulled out when the drive needs to be connected. The above two drives' extension cables are required because the length of the retractable cable is not more than an inch, and it can be difficult to connect them to a PC.

The Freecom FHD-2 PRO, LaCie Rugged RUG U2, LaCie Design by F. A. Porsche 40 GB, and the Transcend StoreJet 2.5 80 GB come with a separate power cable that connects to an additional USB port: normally, these USB drives draw power from the USB data cable, that is, a single port. But in some systems, the power that the port can supply is limited, and the power required to run the hard drive may be insufficient. A separate power connection is therefore required. The Seagate 40 GB drive had a cable with two USB



Freecom
FHD-XS

